

The BIOS software code and all the settings for the PC are stored on a memory chip that's continuously supplied with power by a battery. The battery also powers a real-time clock that keeps accurate time. Hence, these settings (and time values) are retained even when the power is switched off.

Motherboard manufacturers and BIOS vendors frequently release updates, which can be “ flashed ” to the BIOS. In some troubleshooting cases, your only option is to update the BIOS. Look later in this section to learn how.

To enter the BIOS setup, you'll need to press [Delete], or something similar, when your computer is booting up. Depending on the PC, the key may be different—[Esc], [F1], [F10], etc.

2.2 BIOS Beep Codes

When your system has a problem that won't let it start up properly, the first thing you will hear is warning beeps. These could be because of hardware or even because of the BIOS itself.

Unfortunately, beep codes are not standardised across BIOS vendors and motherboard manufacturers. Below are mentioned the beep codes, along with the possible problem that could be causing the beep, and some suggestions towards resolution. These are for two popular BIOS vendors—AMI and Award. If your BIOS is from any other vendor, you will need to refer to the motherboard manufacturer's or the BIOS vendor's manual for details.

Also, motherboard manufacturers may modify the beep codes to their convenience and not maintain consistency. Keep an open mind when you decipher the beep, and don't get into a tizzy if the codes don't match what is in here or in the BIOS vendor's manual! You should always try and contact the manufacturer to get the correct beep codes.